ANDHRA PRADESH

SERVICE AT YOUR FINGER TIPS

By Amarnath K. Menon



TOUCH SCREEN IT minister Nara Lokesh at the Mana Mitra WhatsApp digital services launch, Jan. 30

For devotees heading to the Tirumala temple, booking darshan and stay and even offering donations will soon be as easy as, well, using WhatsApp. But that barely scratches the surface. A month after the Andhra Pradesh government launched 'WhatsApp Governance' for 161 civic services on January 30, the state is now poised to extend the rollout to more programmes.

The Meta-backed WhatsApp, the king of 'unhindered communication' in India, has been coopted as a tool for digital services delivery by the state-run civic service initiative, Mana Mitra. The first such platform in the country, it streamlines the delivery of civic services, allowing citizens to submit requests, access essential information and avail services directly through WhatsApp. It is accessible both in Telugu and English and also as a voice service for those who cannot text on smartphones.

Among the 161 services on offer are redressal of grievances, paying utility bills, booking bus travel tickets, seeking water connections, procuring documents like birth certificates and much more. The digital platform also obviates the need for citizens to visit government offices for certificates and documents. Through WhatsApp, the government will also disseminate crucial information such as weather updates and information on natural disasters, electricity supply and healthcare.

WHATSAPP GOVERNANCE

- **Andhra govt's civic service initiative, Mana Mitra, gets Meta-backed WhatsApp onboard as a tool for digital services delivery**
- **161 civic services available now; 2 million users have already logged in**
- **Security, fraudulent documentation still a worry**

A major concern, though, is whether cyber security measures are in place to prevent data breaches. The state says it has strengthened the forensic and cyber security framework, put in place several checks, and asked all departments to implement stringent cyber security protocols.

Meanwhile, of the two million-odd users who logged in in the first four weeks, over 1.1 million are now active users—an engagement rate of 55 per cent. An IVRS (interactive voice response system) survey also showed that 80.2 per cent users were happy with the WhatsApp features. Education, health, energy, revenue and public grievance redressal were the top five most availed departments and services.

Andhra had reached an agreement with Meta in October 2024 to implement the digital initiative. Incidentally, Mana Mitra is the brainchild of CM Chandrababu Naidu's son and IT and education minister Nara Lokesh. "This is a true transformation in citizen-centric services. Mana Mitra will also help citizens give feedback on the services, and improve accountability," he says.

The government may also introduce QR code verification and Aadhaar authentication to enhance security and reduce the risk of fraudulent documentation. There are other challenges too. RTGS CEO K. Dinesh Kumar points out that one in 10 transactions failed because of server speed limitations. "The early successes prove that effective capacity has to rise. Our goal is to position WhatsApp services as the primary channel for civic interactions with the state," says Kumar. Mana Mitra's focus on accessibility and user familiarity could push daily transaction numbers into the millions in the near future, and furthermore has the potential to eliminate bureaucratic inefficiencies.

The shift to Mana Mitra-based services is not only a technological advancement but also an effort to make state services more accessible and transparent. Yet, while the model showcases the challenges and promises of digital service, there are looming fears over political interference and WhatsApp's role as both facilitator and potential influencer of governance. ■